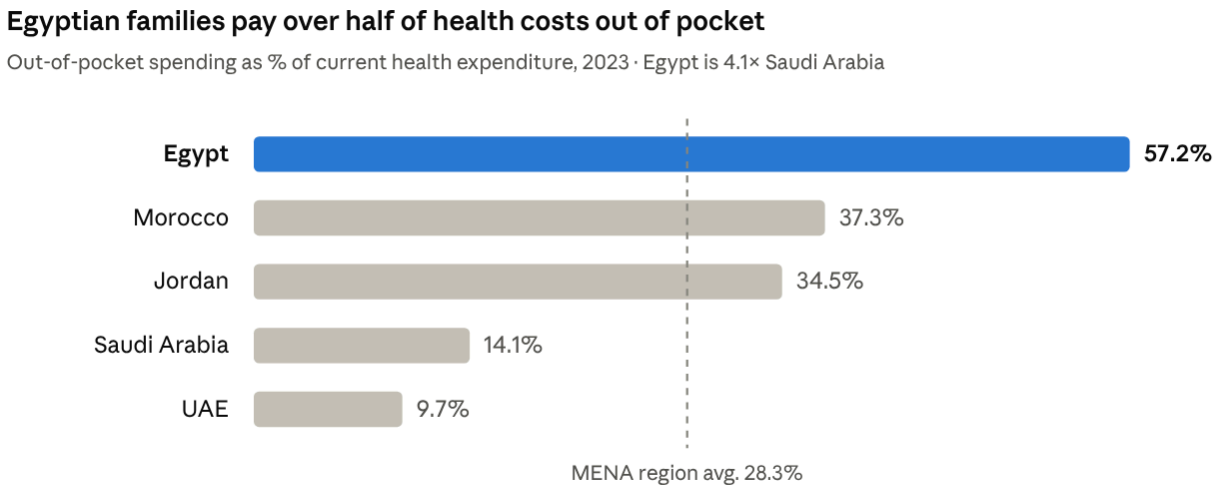
MENA market research

Nov 2, 2026

Start in Egypt with a phone-only app; add Saudi Arabia as a complement to Sehhaty once the cloud features are ready.

- **Need is highest in Egypt.** Families pay 57.2% of health costs out of pocket (2023), over 4× the Saudi share. About 1 in 5 adults has diabetes, and the birth rate is the highest of the five markets.
- **The gap is real.** No government or private app found keeps a family's history and spending together. Egypt's universal insurance is still being rolled out region by region, and no patient app was found.
- **Regulation favours phone-only.** Every market treats health data as sensitive. Cloud storage triggers licences in Egypt and Morocco, and in-country hosting in the UAE (and probably soon KSA). An offline-first MVP avoids most of that.

Health spending: who pays



World Bank SH.XPD.OOPC.CH.ZS (WHO GHED), 2023

The regional average is the World Bank's Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan and Pakistan group. For its middle- and low-income countries alone, the share is 47.3%. A World Bank study of six MENA countries (Who Pays?, 2010, data from 2005–06) found that most out-of-pocket money goes to **medicines, doctor visits and diagnostic tests**. Those are exactly the costs this app tracks. It also found that 7–13% of households face catastrophic health spending. Those figures are about 20 years old, so treat them as background.

Who needs it: chronic disease, births, ageing

About one adult in five has diabetes in four of the five markets. Egypt and Jordan also have the most births per woman. That means long-term medicine reminders and pregnancy/infant tracking are core features, not extras.

Country	Adults 20–79 with diabetes (2024)	Births per woman (2024)	Aged 65+, % of population (2025 est.)
Egypt	22.4%	2.74	5.3%
Saudi Arabia	23.1%	2.31	3.1%
UAE	20.7%	1.21	1.8%
Jordan	20.5%	2.60	4.8%
Morocco	11.9%	2.21	8.5%

Source: World Bank indicators SH.STA.DIAB.ZS (IDF data), SP.DYN.TFRT.IN, SP.POP.65UP.TO.ZS.

- The International Diabetes Federation counts **85 million adults with diabetes in its MENA region (2024)**, about **1 in 3 undiagnosed**. It also reports that **1 in 5 live births** is affected by high blood sugar in pregnancy. Pregnancy Mode's glucose test and blood-sugar log matter here.
- The 65+ share is still small (2–9%), but in absolute numbers that is millions of older people, mostly cared for by their adult children. That makes the caregiver features a selling point to the paying-age generation.

Digital landscape: platforms and competitors

No regional app we checked keeps a family's medical history and its spending together across private clinics and countries. Government platforms are tied to one country or insurer, and most connect providers rather than families. Private apps book doctors or deliver medicines.

Government platforms

Country	Platform	What families get	Gap for this app
Saudi Arabia	Sehhaty (MOH)	Dependents, family doctor, children's vaccination records, medical reports, vitals, saved medicine list	Private-sector visits, costs, insurance cards, scans/photos; KSA only
UAE, Abu Dhabi	Malaffi	Health information exchange: 3,144 connected facilities, all hospitals; portal is for providers	Patients use the Department of Health's Sahatna app (Oct 2024): own and dependents' records, vaccinations, bookings, e-prescriptions; needs UAE Pass. Abu Dhabi only, no spending or insurance-card tracking
UAE, Dubai	NABIDH (DHA)	Shares allergies, medicines, labs, insurance between connected facilities, with patient consent	No patient app; not all facilities connected
Egypt	Universal Health Insurance	Phase 1 (6 governorates) finished July 2025; Phase 2 started in Minya, September 2026	No patient app mentioned; most of the country still outside the system
Morocco	AMO (mandatory insurance)	32M+ beneficiaries, 88% of the population, 2025	Patient app not verified
Jordan	Hakeem (e-health records)	Provider-side record system	Patient app not verified

Private apps

App	What it does	Family history or spending?
Vezeeta	Doctor booking, tele-consults, home visits, medicine delivery; KSA, Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon and more	No
Altibbi	Tele-consults by subscription, AI assistant, pregnancy calculators, Arabic medical content	No

App	What it does	Family history or spending?
Okadoc	Doctor booking and video consults (UAE)	No
Yodawy	Pharmacy benefits with 15 insurers, prescription upload, chronic refills (Egypt)	No
Chefaa	Online pharmacy with prescriptions (Egypt)	No

These apps are **potential partners, not just competitors**. For example, Yodawy or Chefaa for refills, and Vezeeta for booking the follow-up visit the app suggests.

Phones and internet

- **308 million mobile internet users in MENA (46% of the population) in 2024**, forecast 378M by 2031 (GSMA via TelecomLead). Use is 71% in the Gulf vs. 43% in lower-income countries, so offline-first matters.
- **Egypt**: 98.2M internet users (82.7%) and 121M mobile connections, October 2025 (DataReportal).
- **Saudi Arabia**: 34.4M internet users (99%), October 2025 (DataReportal).
- No free, credible source for WhatsApp's share in Egypt or KSA was found; worth confirming before relying on it in a pitch.

Regulation: health data rules

All five countries treat health data as **sensitive**, requiring explicit consent. The cloud is where obligations start: storing data only on the phone avoids most licensing and transfer rules. Two dates matter now. **Egypt's data-protection grace period ends around November 2026**, and **Saudi Arabia's draft rule to keep data in the Kingdom is in consultation until 5 November 2026**.

	Egypt	Saudi Arabia	UAE	Jordan	Morocco
Main law	PDPL 151/2020; Executive Regulations (Decision 816/2025) in force Nov 2025, one-year grace period (CMS)	PDPL (M/19, amended M/148), enforceable Sept 2024; draft amendments Oct 2026 (Reed Smith)	PDPL 45/2021 (executive regulations not yet issued) + **Health ICT Law 2/2019** (CMS)	Law 24/2023, effective March 2024 (Clyde & Co)	Law 09-08 (2009) (CMS)

	Egypt	Saudi Arabia	UAE	Jordan	Morocco
What sensitive data needs	Explicit consent (reportedly written, in Arabic); **regulator licence**; registered data protection officer; 72-hour breach notice	Explicit consent; impact assessment; data protection officer; **SDAIA registration**	Consent; whether a consumer app falls under the Health ICT Law is unclear	Prior written consent; data protection officer; licence from the Board	Explicit consent; **prior CNDP authorisation**
Data leaving the country	**Licence needed for any transfer abroad, including foreign cloud**	Allowed with safeguards today; **draft would require storage in the Kingdom**	**Health data may not leave the UAE** except under Ministerial Decision 51/2021 exceptions	Not to countries with weaker protection; exception for treatment	Only to adequate countries, otherwise authorisation or express consent
Medical-app rules	Medical devices registered with the EDA; no app-specific rule found	**SFDA guidance MDS-G27 (Aug 2025)**: software that analyses an individual's data (not just stores it) is a medical device (SFDA)	Not researched	Not researched	Not researched

Which features could count as a medical device (reading of SFDA MDS-G27, not legal advice):

- **Not a device**: storing and showing records, photos, timelines; plain medicine reminders that don't manage the dose.
- **Likely a device**: dose calculators and drug-interaction warnings (personalised drug recommendations), and possibly growth z-score flags for a specific child.

Summaries of law firms' and regulators' pages; not legal advice. Have a local lawyer confirm before launching cloud or partner features.

Implications for the product

Finding	Change to the proposal
Cloud use triggers licences and data-location rules	Keep the MVP **fully on the phone**; encrypted backup to the user's own Google Drive (not iCloud: Apple guideline 5.1.3). When cloud sync comes, host **in-country** (UAE, KSA) or use end-to-end encryption, and get legal advice first
Cloud OCR is a data transfer	Default to on-device OCR; cloud OCR only with explicit consent and an in-region endpoint
Dose calculator, interaction warnings and growth flags may be medical devices (KSA)	Put them in a **separate clinical module behind a switch**. Launch with plain reminders and records, and add the module after a regulatory review per country
Explicit consent needed, in Arabic in Egypt	Arabic consent screens per feature (sync, OCR, sharing, partners), including consent given by guardians for children
Egypt licence + data protection officer required once data is processed	Budget for a PDPC licence, a DPO and a local representative before turning on any cloud or partner feature in Egypt
High diabetes rates and births	Make chronic-medicine reminders, blood-sugar logs, Pregnancy Mode and Infant Mode part of the MVP
46% mobile internet use in MENA, lower outside the Gulf	Offline-first, small app size, works on older Android phones
Vezeeta, Altibbi, Yodawy, Chefaa don't keep family history	Approach them as **partners** (booking, refills, tele-consults) rather than competing head-on
Sehhaty already covers KSA basics	In KSA, position as the **private-sector and cost** companion to Sehhaty

Sources

Statistics: World Bank: out-of-pocket share · World Bank: diabetes · World Bank: fertility · World Bank: aged 65+ · IDF: MENA region · World Bank: Who Pays? (2010)

Digital landscape: Sehhaty · Malaffi · NABIDH (Gulf News) · Egypt UHI Phase 1 (Ahram) · Egypt UHI Phase 2 (Ahram) · Morocco AMO · Vezeeta · Altibbi · Okadoc · Yodawy · Chefaa · GSMA MENA 2025 (TelecomLead) · DataReportal Egypt 2026 · DataReportal Saudi Arabia 2026

Regulation: CMS: Egypt PDPL regulations · Clyde & Co: Egypt 2026 · Reed Smith: Saudi PDPL amendments · Clyde & Co: Saudi PDPL · SFDA MDS-G27 · CMS: UAE health data · Morgan Lewis: UAE · Clyde & Co: Jordan PDPL · CMS: Morocco · DLA Piper data protection guides

Added Nov 2026: Sahatna launch (Gulf News) · Sijilli (AUB) · Apple App Store Review Guidelines · Google Play User Data policy · Google Play Health apps policy